

Count attackers and legal defenders

Chess Math

THE IDEA

A numerical majority of attackers can suggest a profitable exchange, but move order and piece values control the result. A pinned defender may not be able to recapture, while a king cannot capture onto an attacked square.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Three attackers against two defenders is not automatic victory if the first attacker is a queen and the defenders are pawns. Begin with the cheapest legal capture when comparing an ordinary exchange, then test forcing exceptions.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why can two nominal defenders provide only one legal recapture?

ANSWER AND REASONING

One may be absolutely pinned to its king, or its capture may leave the king checked along another line. Count legal actions in the resulting position.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Count mobility and value alongside the number of defenders.